

Visa.

A founder's case for adding outbound mobility to the Philippine Creative Industries framework.

BASIS	PSA Creative Economy data · RA 11904 / PCIDP MC 103 · a decade of personal advocacy
ASK	An IRR amendment, a Senate hearing, or a Creative Workers Mobility Act
SCALE	₱2.12T economy · 7.51M workers · 30% U.S. visa denial rate
AUDIENCE	Sen. Paolo Benigno "Bam" Aquino IV · for policy review and partnership

Creative is the second-largest sector by workforce in the country.

7.51 million Filipinos work in creative industries — already four times the BPO workforce, approaching agriculture in scale. ₱2.12T value, comparable to OFW remittances.

₱2.12T

Total economic value, 2025 — 7.6% of GDP

7.51M

Filipinos employed — 17.8% of all PH jobs

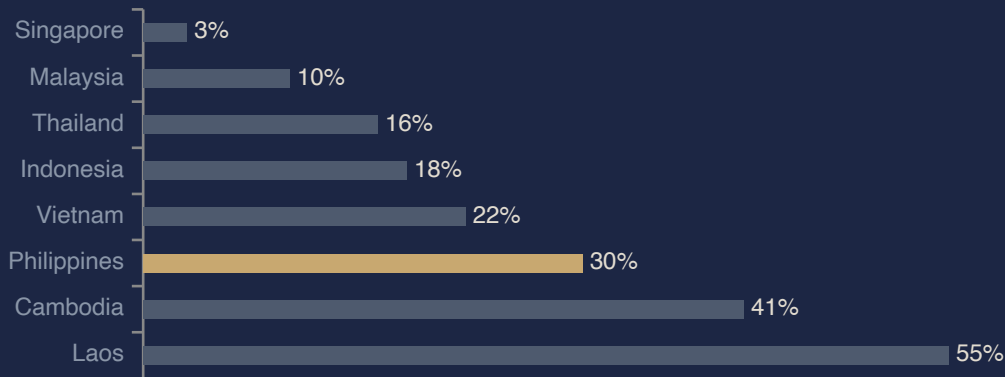
4×

the workforce of the entire BPO industry (1.9M)

Source. PSA Creative Economy 2025; IBPAP 2025; BSP 2025.

Filipinos face the third-highest U.S. tourist-visa denial rate in Southeast Asia.

U.S. B-visa refusal rates by country of nationality, fiscal year 2024.



Source: U.S. Dept of State FY24; SchengenVisaInfo PH 2023.

THE ASYMMETRY

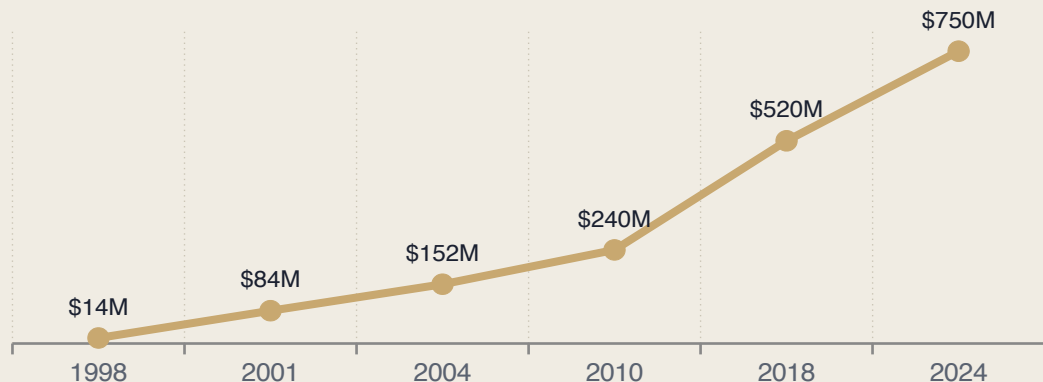
U.S., Korean, and Japanese artists enter the Philippines visa-free.

Filipino artists going the other way: 3-month process, \$185 fee, embassy interview, provincial travel — for a 30% chance of refusal.

***Touring artists must apply simultaneously.
One delay drops a city.***

Korea's culture spend rose sixfold in three years — then Hallyu broke globally.

South Korean government spending on cultural industries, USD millions. The Philippines is already at Korea's current GDP share — without comparable state investment.



PHILIPPINES TODAY (2025)

7.6%

of GDP from creative industries — already at Korea's current share, without comparable state investment.

Post-Hallyu in size. Pre-Hallyu in policy.

Source. KOCCA; Korean Ministry of Culture, Sports and Tourism; PSA Creative Economy 2025.

Filipino artists put their visa frustration on a global chart.

SB19 — 'VISA' · released 20 February 2026 · debuted #6 on the U.S. World Digital Song Sales chart · 3 months in flight globally.

“*Filipino **artists, athletes, and professionals** all face the same challenges with visa processes.*”

— SB19, on releasing 'VISA'

50+

countries streaming daily

3 months

since release — Overton window moved

#6

U.S. World Digital Song Sales debut

Source. Inquirer Entertainment; Lifestyle Inquirer; GMA.

A decade ago — before SB19 — the same visa wall already stood.

A personal note before the policy ask.

This advocacy isn't new for me.

In 2014 I was a BPO call center agent. I was also part of a Filipino dance cover group called **Se-Eon** with Stell, winning regional competitions on our own savings.

That same year, Stell and I met BTS backstage — during their early 'Danger' era, before they became the biggest band in the world.

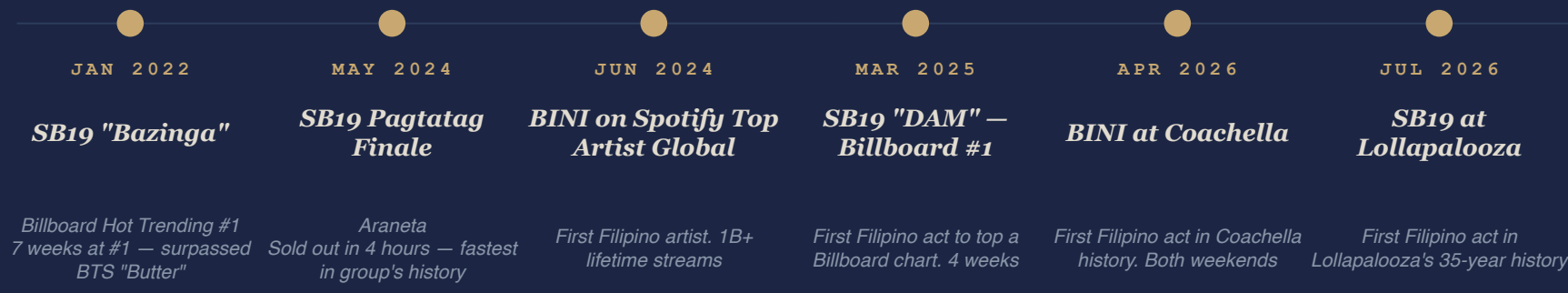
They had state-backed scaffolding when they crossed borders. Filipino artists had nothing. ***We were on our own.***

*The song 'VISA' is one expression of that thinking. ***This meeting is another.****

Source. GMA News Online; Wikipedia (Josh Cullen, musician); Radar.ph.

Six Filipino firsts on global stages. None state-supported.

Each entry below is the first time any Filipino act achieved the listed milestone. None received dedicated state-export support.



TAKEAWAY Six Filipino firsts in four years. **PCIDP MC 103 has no music-export budget line.**

Source. Rolling Stone; GMA; Billboard PH; Koreaboo; PARI; Korea Herald.

The framework is already signed. The mobility chapter is missing.

Three current Marcos-administration instruments already cover creative-industry development. None addresses outbound mobility.

2022

RA 11904

Philippine Creative Industries Development Act Released by Sec. Manalo

Established creative industries as a national priority. DTI lead agency. Created the Creative Industries Development Council.

DEC 2024

DFA Soft Power Roadmap

Released by Sec. Manalo

Cultural diplomacy as a pillar of Bagong Pilipinas. The Office of Cultural Diplomacy already issues endorsement letters.

OCT 2025

PCIDP MC No. 103

Signed by Exec. Sec. Bersamin

10-year creative-economy implementation plan. Already commits to "increase global market presence for Filipino content."

*The President signed the framework. The agencies have the mandate. **The 10-year clock is already running.***

Source. LawPhil (RA 11904); DFA via PNA; PCO; Supreme Court E-Library (MC 103).

Korea built five mobility instruments. PH has none.

Side-by-side: the export-support tools Korea built between 1998–2010, and their status in the Philippines today.

INSTRUMENT	KOREA	PHILIPPINES
Dedicated content-export agency	KOCCA (2009)	—
State-backed bilateral cultural treaties	20+ co-production agreements	—
DFA endorsement protocol for artists	Through MOFA cultural attachés	Ad hoc, request-by-request
Visa fast-track / talent-mobility track	E-6 reciprocity, MOFA support	—
Standalone music-export budget	KRW 1 trillion KOCCA budget (2024)	Not in PCIDP MC 103

TAKEAWAY *Four of five instruments don't exist on the PH side. **The mobility pillar belongs in the PCIDP IRR update.***

Source. KOCCA; Korean Foundation for Cultural Exchange; PCIDP MC 103.

Three ways to add a mobility pillar to the PCIDP.

Graded by ambition and timeline. The senator picks what fits.

OPTION A

Convene a Senate hearing.

Lowest-cost move

- Senate Committee on Culture & the Arts
- Calls DFA + DTI + NCCA to the table
- Public · builds record · generates momentum

30 – 60 days · minimal cost

OPTION B

Push the IRR amendment.

Surgical option

- Direct request to DTI + NCCA
- Adds Mobility Pillar to PCIDP IRR
- We provide draft IRR language

6 – 12 months · no new appropriation

OPTION C

File the bill.

Legacy move — you as principal author

- Creative Workers Mobility Act
- Codifies the Mobility Pillar in statute
- Permanent inter-agency body

1 – 2 years · carries the next decade

*We'd want majority cover. **We trust your judgment on the co-author.***

You already solved this for the athletes. Filipino artists are asking for the same.

“

*We have tremendous talent and potential to conquer the global gaming arena, which is why we worked with the eSports community to organize PeSPA **and to resolve visa issues when they compete abroad.***

— SEN. BAM AQUINO, ON PESPA AND FILIPINO ESPORTS · 2017

You organized PeSPA. You authored Senate Resolution 276. The athletes you championed already have the playbook **you built**.
The creative economy is already **four times the BPO workforce**.

*You've already done it for the athletes. **We came to you because nobody else has built this lane.***

Source. bamaquino.com (PeSPA / esports statements); Sunstar Manila (SR 276).